Home of the Arabica: Tata Coffee's Jumboor estate

A glimpse of the award-winning estate's coffee production and sustainable ecosystem

Nestled in the gentle slopes of the Western Ghats, in the northern highlands of Coorg in Karnataka, at an altitude of 950-1000 meters above the mean sea level, lies one of Tata's most treasured coffee plantations, the Jumboor estate.

Lauded for its eco-friendly practices, sustainability efforts and worker relations, the estate recently garnered international acclaim for its efforts to preserve and hone the craft of its coffee — the Jumboor Gold, an exquisite yellow bourbon Arabica, cultivated on the sprawling estate.

The estate, recipient of the Sixth Ernesto Illy International Coffee Awards 2021, received the award in two acclaimed categories: 'India's Best Coffee' and 'Best of the Best', decided by an esteemed panel of coffee connoisseurs. The Ernesto Illy International Coffee Award, Le Café, Italy, is granted to the producer of the best sustainable and quality coffee from amongst leading coffee-growing countries of the world.

Coffee Production

Arabica, which is predominantly planted across the 390-hectare Jumboor estate, blooms in spring and the fruits are handpicked when fully ripe and processed. The cherries are pulped, naturally fermented, and then mechanically washed and soaked in water. The parchments are washed using pure mountain spring water; expert hands then carefully spread out the beans on concrete drying yards, using the 'table-drying' technique. The controlled, slow sun-drying process helps to bring out the flavour, for which the Arabica is renowned for over a century.

Unique geographical characteristics

According to Nachappa B.M, the representative of Jumboor estate, certain elements make the shade-grown coffee at Jumboor really special. The organic-rich soil variety, high altitude, and 85-90 inches of rainfall, which is well-distributed throughout the year are among the contributing factors for the rich and bold aroma of the coffee. The estate is also crisscrossed with seasonal streams, and Tata Coffee earmarks areas around the streams as 'no cultivation' zones so as to not to disturb the aqua bodies and the natural flow of water. The estate also shares its space with a variety of flora like wild figs, citrus trees, Jack fruit, wild Mango, Sapota and other wild fruit species and fauna such as boars,

snakes, wild fowls, Indian Gaur and Barking deer. It also takes steps to conserve honeybees, for which honey-boxes are placed across the plantation to facilitate pollination and to feed the bees during the dry season.



Bio-control measures used to curb pests

At Jumboor, one of the most common pests of the shade-grown Arabica variety is the white stem borer. To control it, use of pesticides and chemicals is avoided, instead bio-control measures such as tracing, stumping/uprooting, destruction of affected plants and pheromone traps are adopted. The borer-affected plants show wilting symptoms, especially the drooping of the first pair of leaves on branches. Such plants are uprooted immediately and destroyed by burning. The coffee white stem borer pheromone trap is installed on coffee estates for monitoring and trapping the beetles during the period of April-May and October-December to curb infestation.

Waste management

Jumboor also has a very efficient waste management system. The enzymes are used to neutralize the Ph of effluents and then reused for irrigation purpose. The quantity of effluent is contained within the estate; all emissions and waste generated are within the limits prescribed by the Karnataka State Pollution Control Board.

Water harvesting

Owing to plentiful precipitation, the estate has a sturdy water harvesting system in place. This water is also used for irrigation purposes. These irrigation ponds (tapped with a GPS system to effectively use water consumption) are a part of Tata Coffee's unique lake-in-lake model which offers a holistic solution to utilise the run-off collected in the lakes and replenish the underground water reserve. These natural water storage ponds, 253 in numbers and at 34 lakh cubic metres, store excess rainwater capacity across an area of 120 hectares. Extensive scientific rain water harvesting techniques have ensured that irrigation is now completely self-reliant. Surface water analysis is carried out for portability during the rainiest part of the year to assess and confirm that agricultural activity is not contaminating the water resources at entry and exit points

The people of Jumboor

Finally, Jumboor owes its success to managerial efficiency and the enthusiasm with which the employees take care of the coffee, which is an intrinsic part of their lives! Training is also imparted to high-school dropouts who wish to work at the plantation. Employment at the estate ensures inclusive and equitable quality education, including a school for the differently abled, promoting lifelong learning opportunities, achieving gender equality and women empowerment. 53 percent of the workforce at Tata Coffee, working at the plantation, hospital, factories and in corporate functions, comprises women.

> The Jumboor Giling Basah — the term 'Giling Basah' is the process of wet grinding to remove the hulls of Arabic coffee that is largely responsible for the cupping quality — is a limited edition microlot coffee, which is a part of Tata Coffee's Sonnets, a range of premium, artisanal, single-origin Arabica bean coffees. It boasts of exquisite dark chocolate notes and a citrusy tinge for a bitter-sweet aftertaste.

— Dhruv Nimbalkar

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